

Our Country

In the late 18th century, nationalism emerged in Europe and the American colonies as a force for liberty, equality, and fraternity. But during the 19th century, nationalism revealed its uglier side, proving to be an equally strong force for militarism, oppression, and racism.

BEFORE

Until the 18th century the idea of the nation-state was linked to the monarchy and, in smaller states, people were unified by shared language and culture.



KING AND COUNTRY

Europe comprised a small number of powerful kingdoms—Britain and France were the oldest, with the Netherlands, Portugal, Spain, and Sweden emerging between the 15th and 17th centuries. Only in politically independent kingdoms was there any sense of nationhood. This was reinforced by **loyalty to the crown**, the flag, and, later, by patron saints.

CULTURAL NATIONALISM

In smaller states and principalities—territories ruled by a prince—political loyalties were localized, but a sense of unity was provided by **common language and culture**. Around 1765 German historian Friedrich Meinecke observed a single national spirit even “where 20 principalities could be seen during a day’s journey.”

The term nationalism describes a loyalty to one’s nation, pride in its history and culture, a belief that the nation’s interests are of primary importance, and a patriotic desire to achieve or maintain its independence.

Nationalism emerged as a political force in the late 18th century, and since then, the idea that nations have the right to form their own political states has shaped the map of the world as we know it today. This ideal, known as national self-determination, inspired major upheavals, such as the American Revolution (see pp.298–99), provided the impetus for smaller nations to seek independence from large empires, and encouraged nations divided into a collection of small states, or principalities, such as Germany and Italy, to seek unification.

Nations or nationalism?

Although the word “nation” is commonly used to describe a state or country, it is technically a group of people united by ethnicity, culture, language, and/or religion. A state is

Liberty Leading the People

This painting of the July Revolution of 1830 that made Louis-Philippe the French king is both a depiction of and an act of nationalism. The artist Eugene Delacroix wrote: “If I haven’t fought for my country at least I’ll paint for her.”

“Our country... may she always be in the right; but our country, right or wrong.”

STEPHEN DECATUR, US NAVAL OFFICER, 1816

FRENCH SOLDIER (1790–UNKNOWN)

NICOLAS CHAUVIN

Chauvin was an idealistic young soldier whose fierce patriotism remained undiminished even though he was wounded numerous times while serving in Napoleon’s Grand Army (see pp.304–07). Napoleon decorated Chauvin with the Saber of Honor, but when his brand of unquestioning nationalism fell out of fashion, he found himself satirized in several French plays. As a result of his unfortunate fame, the name “chauvinist” is now applied disparagingly to those who display excessive belief in the superiority of their country or of any other cause they embrace.



defined as a geographical territory with its own independent government. These are not always the same thing—for example, the Kurdish people are a nation with no defined state, while South Africa under apartheid (see pp.454–55) was a state whose nations were forcibly divided (hence its new self-image as a multicultural “Rainbow Nation”). A country whose

